

Pricing Guide

These are suggested starting rates. Ashley sets the final numbers. The logic behind them is laid out so she can adjust confidently.

The market (Pittsburgh area, 2026)

Reference point	Typical range	What it tells us
Employee admin assistant / receptionist wage, Pittsburgh metro	~\$18– 24/hr	What the business pays its own staff, before payroll tax, benefits, PTO and hiring costs (usually +25–40%)
Temp agency bill rate for admin / reception (what the business pays the agency)	~\$28– 40/hr	Her direct competitor. The agency keeps a large share of this
Freelance virtual / personal assistants	~\$30– 50/hr	Independent, flexible help commands a premium

Positioning: priced **at or slightly below a temp agency**, with no agency contract, no minimum week and a person they know by name. Businesses win on cost, and Ashley earns far more than an agency temp would pay her.

Recommended rates

Service	Rate	Notes
Business / office / school help	\$35/hr	3-hour minimum per visit (\$105)
Full day (up to 8 hrs on site)	\$260/day	~7% savings vs. hourly. Encourages bigger bookings
Week block (5 full days)	\$1,200/week	For leave coverage and vacancies
Personal assistant / household (individuals)	\$32/hr	2-hour minimum. Organizing, errands, appointments, paperwork
Same-day call-off coverage	+\$10/hr	Booked with less than 24 hours' notice. You're paying for the rescue
Special projects	Flat quote	Estimate the hours × \$35, add 15% buffer. Clients love a fixed price
Errand mileage	IRS rate (76¢/mile for July–Dec 2026)	Only for driving <i>during</i> a job (errands, supply runs), not the commute to the client
Nonprofits, churches, schools	10% off	Optional goodwill discount. These are great referral sources

"Backup on Call" plan (month 3+): for a favorite client, **\$150/month** retainer guarantees first priority for call-offs and includes 4 hours; extra hours at \$35. It smooths out income and makes her the automatic first call.

What she actually keeps

Self-employed people pay both halves of Social Security and Medicare, so a good rule of thumb is to **set aside 25–30% of every payment for taxes** (details in the Business Setup Checklist).

Billable hours / week	Weekly revenue @ \$35	Yearly (48 weeks)	Set aside ~28%	Take-home (approx.)
15	\$525	\$25,200	\$7,056	~\$18,100
25	\$875	\$42,000	\$11,760	~\$30,200
32	\$1,120	\$53,760	\$15,050	~\$38,700

Before business expenses (insurance, phone, marketing, mileage), which are mostly tax-deductible. Actual tax depends on her whole household situation, so confirm with a tax preparer.

Why not charge \$22/hr like an employee wage? Because as a business she covers her own taxes, has no paid time off, no benefits, no guaranteed hours and unbilled time spent marketing and driving. \$35 as a business ≈ \$22–25 as an employee. Undercharging is the #1 reason new service businesses fail.

Raising prices

- Review rates every January. A \$2–3/hr increase per year is normal.
- When she's regularly turning work away, raise rates for **new** clients first.
- Give existing clients 30 days' notice of any change.

Getting paid

- **Invoice** weekly, or at job end for short jobs. Payment due within 15 days (businesses) or on completion (individuals).
- **Accept:** check, Venmo Business, Zelle, or card through Square / PayPal invoices (card fees are ~3%, so build that into pricing or add a small card fee).
- **Free invoicing:** Wave, Square Invoices, or the free tier of QuickBooks Solopreneur alternatives. A Google Sheets template works fine at first.
- Keep a simple log of **date · client · hours · amount · paid date** for every job. It makes taxes easy.